from Mudhol, who later became deputy chief minister, and Srinivas Prasad, who switched in 2016. Even Ashwathnarayan moved into the party from the JD(S) in the early 2000s. When I asked him how difficult it was to adjust to a cadre-based and ideological party, he said, 'It's about integration and function. We have objectives and programmes. It's a clear mandate, and if you change you can join us. Each organisation has its own mechanism. You have to fit into it. Other parties are used to big boss deciding everything. Here you don't see big bosses.'[103] Another BJP leader said, 'A lot of people came in because they have a shot at power. They came in because they can be ministers[,] which they can't be with JD(S). They think, why waste time. It's a big motivation for them to come to power.'[104]

Did the entry of defectors from other parties dilute the BJP? 'Ideology kept getting diluted,' lamented a senior leader. 'Power has become the ideology now. Power is necessary, and ideology *ka sawal kahan raha ab* [where's the question of ideology then].' He pointed to the first BJP alliance with JD(S) in 2004, which broke up in 2007, leading to the collapse of the BJP-led government. At the same time, he explained, 'JD(S) was a stepping stone to power for us. We had eighteen ministers. By taking power, the party became resourceful.'[105] In that sense, it was only following the advice that B.L. Mehta gave to the Jan Sangh in the 1960s (see Chapter 8): use power as a means of expansion.

Similarly, the national ascent of Vajpayee in the late 1990s and of Modi after 2014 helped the BJP in Karnataka. 'People get attracted to power,' said a senior BJP legislator. 'People want power. People start gravitating towards a party that has power as they can see the benefit of that. Once you are in power, people start getting attracted to you. So, we won 110 seats in 2008 … Coming to power at the Centre under Vajpayee in the late 1990s hugely helped us because it attracted people from other parties and it strengthened our party.' Few remember that, in 2004, when Vajpayee's BJP lost the general election nationally, it still won a majority in Karnataka, taking seventeen of the twenty-eight state seats in Parliament. In the 2018 state assembly poll, the 'Narendra Modi factor worked in at least fifteen seats in assembly election', says a Bengaluru-based